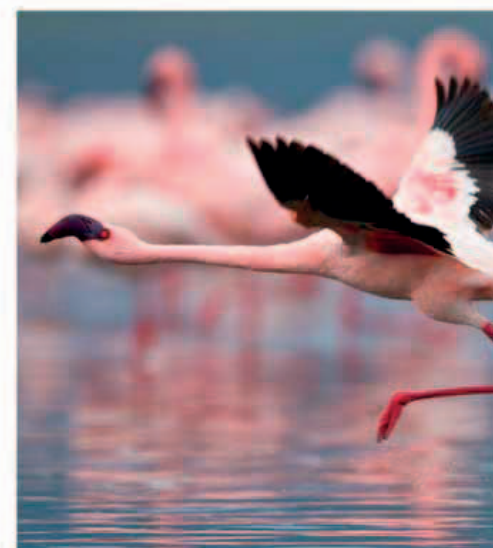
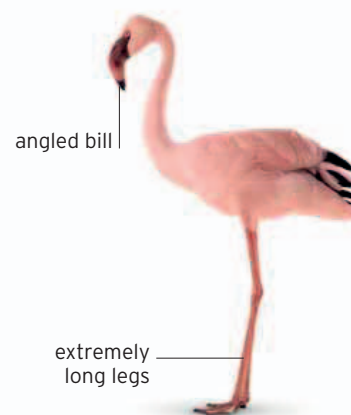


Lesser flamingo

Phoenicopterus minor



The lesser flamingo is an iconic bird of the African Rift Valley. Flocks hundreds of thousands strong turn whole landscapes pink at the steaming fringes of inhospitable alkaline lakes. In East Africa there are 3–4 million lesser flamingos; smaller populations live in southern Africa, including the Etosha Pan, and in India.

Incredible colonies

These monogamous birds breed in huge colonies on remote, caustic alkaline mudflats, exposed to searing heat, which are almost impossible for mammalian predators to reach. Their nests are small cones of mud and soda crystals, holding a single egg that hatches after 28 days. When two weeks old, chicks form herds of hundreds of thousands, attended by just one or two

adults, leaving the parents free to find food. Chicks form lines up to 20 miles (30 km) long, and the nurseries are driven up to 30 miles (50 km) across burning mud to reach shallow freshwater lagoons.

Although a million or more flamingos may gather, only a small proportion breed each year. Of East Africa's 1.5 million pairs, an average of 319,000 breed, rearing 140,000 young. Half of them die before reaching breeding age, so to maintain the population, lesser flamingos require an adult lifespan of more than 20 years.

Natural mortality of full-grown birds, mainly from eagles and marabou storks, is low, but disturbance caused by tourism, including low-flying aircraft, may be more damaging, and there are increasing threats from pollution and industrial development.

- ↔ 32–35½ in (80–90 cm)
- ⚖ Up to 2 kg (4 lb)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Algae
- 🏠 



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S. Africa,
S. Asia

